reader III

Maravilloso Reading Group

If we build politically by virtue of the vulnerability of our bodies, then we have to recognize the vulnerability of the body as something indisputable.

1

El Inicio / The Beginning and selected quotes from Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia

2

Recipe for becoming a narco by Heriberto Yépez

3

Brickmakers by Selva Almada

4

Queen, Slave, Woman from This is Not Miami by Fernanda Melchor

9

Bad Girls by Camila Sosa Villada

11

Other from Cockfight by María Fernanda Ampuero

[...]

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We do not ignore the fact that the resistance of endriago subjects - despite being part of a contradictory multitude - does make it descursively possible to think about the need for an effective, non-dystopian dissidence necessarily aligned with questions of gender disobedience and transfeminism. It must create shared alternatives that spur the active participation of civil society (...) Transfeminism shows us that this resistance must emerge out of alliances that are not grounded in nationalist, identitarian or essentialist precepts, but rather they should debunk these ideas, as they are profoundly reactionary even when used by progressive movements. This would open the way for participation, resistance and agency for those we have called here the becoming-queer.

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Thinking through our bodies is a way to question the unidirectionality of political and economic norms, on a search for other channels. Thus, we must think of pain as a political resource that must not confine us to inaction, but rather might lead us to the development of a reflexive process resulting in an identification with suffering itself, (...)

Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia
[selected fragments]

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(...) we must refute the argument that the market is a self-directed, unfettered, and unfathomable phenomenon, since it can be better understood as a well-organized, highly-managed phenomenon, steeped in the logics of the new Darwinist, ultra-capitalist wing. We could say that the market is a highly-organized structure, regulated and managed by specific subjects—who can be held accountable—since "the market needs rules and these rules have to be instituted by someone."

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Where everything seems to lie dormant, the force of capitalism has ramped up desire itself; the media and their propagation of consumerist desire work to catalyze it even further. As this acceleration intensifies, potential energy becomes kinetic energy in an enormous and unremitting process. Desire is crystallized in certain practices that become commodities; then subject-particles that once seemed harmless fall into place, embed themselves in us. Little by little, in a dispersed and erratic fashion, our tacit agreements around ethics and submission are destroyed. Brutal economic realities and their circumstances mean that bodies, subjects, and flesh become centers, merchandise, and exchange. Capital accumulation through disturbance, reformulation, and infiltration of the production process through necroempowerments. Rupture. Disruption.

Esto es Tijuana

The fury of clouds that is the Pacific Ocean.

A dismembered torso strewn across the highway at rush hour. Cigarettes lit in rapid succession. The neon lights of the red-light district, microscopic universes. Arboreal metastasis.

Narcos. Machismo. Silicone Land. Whore-Barbie's Factory. High caliber weapons laughing, cackling. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Leaving and staying at the same time. Finding another way to say that everything is an eternal return. Irrevocable trajectories and irrevocable women. Violence, tedium and the everyday grind: overdrawn on all accounts. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The word *Bienvenidos* laughing in my face. The word *Bienvenidos* meaning every entrance is an exit. Silence stabs. The desert boils. Migrant screams ring out. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Donkey-zebras imitating nostalgia. Shiny new cars. Enraged taxis. The head repeats an atrocious mantra, "open (yourself) up on the inside." Get into the game. See the Fire. Escape constantly and once and for all bet on winning. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Where the questions where, when and why might not exist, the same as the word "never." Where half of the half does not compute. Where *Interminably* is the same as *Now.*

City of *over and over again.* Where the truth is never known. Where all words—including the word incest—portend multiple histories. Where *mi casa es su casa.* Where *su casa no es mi casa.* Where yes, actually, *su casa es mi caza*: I'm on a hunt and your house is my prey. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La línea never frees itself from the metallic serpent on either side.

A *frontera*-woman looks like death and walks with one hand on her revolver. The syringe-man unsuccessfully attempts to fly along the middle of the metal serpent. The transparent and the true. The piercing.

The first and the third world. The border. El bordo. Hell. The other part of the other side. The other side of the other side. The *This* side of the *Other* side. The happy world of disenchantment. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The limit. The perimeter. The edge of the world. He/she/they/what is dragged behind. The shore that licks white, middle-class, civilized culture and brings it to its end. The time bomb that detonates us. San Diego's garage.

The divided sea laughing raucously *entre las olas. Entre Las Solas.* In the waves and in all the women on their own. The grayness. The paradox. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The *copyright* of the end. *Cartel-right.* Gore capitalism. *Hotels, attractions, nightlife, restaurants, weather and border crossing...*

A blind search for combinatorics. Two million possibilities. *Crunchy, spicy and totally addictive-fabulous blends. Depictions of sodomy, bestiality, alternative sexual practices, racial and ethnic stereotypes. This is Tijuana.*

Everything that enters or leaves the city comes from two parts. Everything here leaves in two or more parts. *You can have whatever you can buy.* City of businesses. Virgin girls *for sale.* Affordable prices for foreigners. Luis Donaldo Colosio Acribillado (a.k.a Bullet-Riddled). Música de banda. Morgue. Techno. NAFTA. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La Tía Juana, Tiguana, Tiuana, Teguana, Tiwana, Tijuan, Ticuan, TJ, Tijuas: you can call her whatever you want because Tijuana—like every other word—means nothing and means: "beside the sea."

Esto es *Queerland.* "Aquí empieza la patria / The homeland begins here."

Esto es Tijuana.

At the brink of el bordo, I become blade.

Tijuana is affectionate. Unfathomable. Full of possibilities.

To be in love with a psychopath and to say so with a smile.

You should leave now. This is Tijuana.

Recipe for becoming a narco

—Heriberto Yépez, 2008, from "Receta para cocinar a la parrilla," *Millenio*. Suplemento Laberinto, México, D. F.

From a very early age, grind up your kid's feelings, body and desires. Tell your kid that you know more about them than they do. Tell your kid that everything they do is "bad." (Do this as regularly as possible.) As you work to give form to a person marked by this sense of incompleteness, add machismo, classism, racism and misogyny into the mix. Do this until you have successfully created a person who is only "complete" when they cut others down. (Derision is the key ingredient in this traditional dish.)

Once your kid reaches puberty, increase the level of your familiar authoritarianism. Use emotional blackmail or overt violence. Maintain a warlike familiar environment. By this time, your kid will be looking for any way to stand out. You and your society must block any attempt to excel through education, love or work.

Bring the mixture to boil with narcocorridos and Hollywood movies. Add two grams of cocaine.

Or bake it with marijuana or meth (sold without prescription). On low heat, let your kid roam the streets. There your kid will find the nearest gang, cop, cartel, or army. Then he will have "respect." And he will take his revenge on you and on the entire society. For dessert, play the victim and ask yourself why there are such heartless people in the world when you yourself are so sweet.

The Tamais had married young and with family on the way. Before saying yes to the priest, Celina had said yes to her boyfriend, to the urgency of his kisses that left her neck and shoulders covered in tiny bruises. Which was also like saying no to her father, who disapproved of the relationship.

The first time was uncomfortable and painful, a far cry from the Corín Tellado stories that fuelled her teenage fantasies. They'd done it in the middle of a dance, at the Húngaro. After the DJ stopped playing the latest hits and put on some milongas and chamamés for the older couples and the mothers and aunts who were there as chaperones, and before the live band showed up.

Tamai took Celina by the arm and led her from the dance. They emerged into the warm night and made their way through the parked cars. Celina glimpsed arms and legs moving inside some of the vehicles, blurry behind the steamed-up glass: privileged girls who at least had a private cubicle in which to give themselves away.

They reached a cluster of trees and Tamai leaned her against a trunk. She felt the rough bark scratching her back, which her summer dress left bare. She clutched her knickers in one fist, and the other she bit so as not to cry out when her boyfriend pushed all the way inside her.

When it was over, she rearranged her clothes in a daze. Tamai, panting, fell back against the tree and lit a cigarette, then pulled her in with one arm and kissed her on the forehead.

'Can't get pregnant standing up,' he murmured.

Estela Miranda woke before dawn. She'd been dreaming about carnival. It was the end of December, and she'd been up late the night before embroidering costumes for the Ara Sunú dance troupe. In her dream, despite being pregnant, she was the queen again. Dancing on the float in very high heels, a bra and miniskirt, the gold lamé cloak, and the crown perched on her short hair. Her whole body, including her belly, was covered in glitter. From her position on the trailer-turned-royal-carriage, she saw some kids approaching with water balloons in their hands. Against carnival rules – not to get the queen wet – the boys took aim with their liquid grenades and the multi-coloured balloons hit their target, soaking her from head to toe.

Far from annoyed, Estela, who'd been the Ara Sunú queen at several carnivals running and knew her way around the royal airs and graces, smiled and silently threatened them with her sceptre, shaking her hips all the while to the rhythm of the drums.

When she awoke and sat up in bed, there was still a smile on her lips, the smile that had been photographed by every newspaper in the region. She switched on the lamp and when she pulled back the sheets a few sequins went flying; she must have carried them into bed with her after all the hours of embroidery. Her waters had broken, and the mattress underneath her was sopping wet. The other side was dry and empty. Miranda was off playing Mus, which he did every night, at the Imperio bar.

She felt her heart beating harder. But it was joy, not fear. She knew exactly what she had to do: get dressed, grab the little bag she'd packed weeks ago, leave a note for her husband, walk the two blocks to the neighbour who had a phone – she was expecting her, and knew Estela might come knocking at any time of the day or night and ask her to call a taxi – and take a towel, too, to put on the car seat so she didn't dirty the upholstery. She'd been keeping the money for the journey separate in her purse.

Everything happened just the way she'd planned. Never letting her carnival-queen smile falter, she bore the first pains, which came as she was at her neighbour's, waiting for the car. The woman offered to go with her to the hospital, but Estela said no, she should go back to bed, she'd already done enough.

Estela Miranda knew full well: although you make children with somebody else, you bring them into the world alone.

'Evangelina the Second,
with Artemis's style:
Venus bitterly envies
The candour of your smile.'
— Anonymous poem published in
El Dictamen newspaper, 1982

'Downtown Veracruz is full of ghosts,' my father used to say whenever we went past his family's first home in the city, where they moved from Baja California: a gloomy shared tenement with a central patio on Avenida 5 de Mayo, now completely deserted. Like so many other buildings in the city's historic centre, the house where my father took his first steps is today a rubble-filled ruin, a haunt for drunkards, mangy cats and spectres who languish among the rubbish and overgrown weeds and, every so often, spook the fine people of Veracruz, as the legendary Headless Priest used to do, or the souls of the women raped and murdered by the Dutch pirate Laurens de Graaf's men in the colonial period. Ghosts in rags, sleeping off their hangovers in alleyways; ghouls in human form poking their drunken faces through the broken trellises on the balconies; silhouettes that, out of charity or sheer cunning, occupy the wreckages of those vast coral stone houses, old mansions that collapse onto the pavement below, on windy days sometimes fatally, to the total indifference of their lawful owners, criollo big shots who would rather sit back and watch their inheritance fall to pieces than use up time, money and influence on restoring this heritage site. //

The National Lottery building on Independencia, while nowhere near as old as many of the derelict houses steadily crumbling into the downtown streets, forms part of this ghostly panorama: a labyrinth of apartments, offices and shops distributed across six floors and still occupied by a handful of senior citizens who can't be evicted because of old tenancy laws – men and women who live by candlelight, without running water or electricity, and who tell stories of strange noises in the building's hallways: marbles and balls bouncing across the floors of boarded-up rooms, shouts and moans from those who perished in the fire that ravaged the building in the late seventies, or children's laughter and the patter of small feet going up and down the stairs. → Historiar el

Miguel, pensioner: 'I lived in the National Lottery building for a long time, above Telas de México, the textiles shop on the corner of Calle Rayón and Independencia... It used to house the lottery offices, hence the name, but they moved when the fire broke out in Telas de México... After that, the building's owners came out with some crap about how they planned to renovate the apartments, but instead they cut off the electricity and water and drove us all out... I resisted because, quite honestly, I couldn't afford to go anywhere else; I wanted a rent-controlled apartment and that's why I clung on, but in the end the constant battle wore me down... And the truth is I never much liked living in that building... I don't know if you noticed when you went but it's got a bad vibe, don't you think?... Sort of like you can't relax in there, I can't explain it... And at night you hear horrible noises, screaming and groaning... We had a neighbour, Doña Something, she's dead now but she was very sensitive to these things... She was the one who actually saw the two boys, Evangelina's sons, playing on the stairs, months after the crime was uncovered... I think that's why the owners left the place to rot; maybe they just didn't want anyone to remember what had happened in that apartment.'

On 7 April 1989, a story broke concerning apartment 501 of the National Lottery building: in an uncontrollable fit of rage, a twenty-four-year-old woman had murdered her two young sons.

That incident alone would have provided enough material for weeks' worth of café gossip, before passing into merciful oblivion. But two specific details of the crime ensured that the story would transcend the tabloid crime pages to be written into popular legend: first, less than six years earlier, the offender, Evangelina Tejera Bosada, had been crowned the Queen of Veracruz Carnival, an honour that, even today, is widely considered the highest aspiration for any girl from an upstanding family in the city; and second, having repeatedly smashed her sons' skulls against the floor, Tejera Bosada went on to carve up their bodies and bury them in a large plant pot, which she then put out on her apartment balcony. //

The first reports of Tejera Bosada's arrest and the discovery of the bodies of Jaime and Juan Miguel – ages three and two, respectively – appeared on Friday, 7 April 1989, in Veracruz's biggest newspapers. According to popular legend, however, the story began in the middle of March, when the residents of the National Lottery building supposedly detected a nasty smell. Only nineteen-year-old Juan Miguel Tejera Bosada, visiting his sister's apartment, dared to link the smell to the unexplained absence of his two little nephews.

In initial news reports, the young woman, described as pale and doleful, denied responsibility for the children's deaths. 'I didn't kill my children,' she declared before the court. 'I just buried them after they died. My mother cut me off so I had no way of feeding them.' Dressed in a man's T-shirt and dirty trainers, Tejera Bosada explained to Judge Carlos Rodríguez Moreno that her mother had ended her financial support upon discovering that her daughter was pregnant and that the baby's father was married and had another family. The younger child, she confirmed, was fathered by same man, Mario de la Rosa Villanueva, but since he had refused to legally acknowledge either of the two boys, Evangelina had registered them under her maiden name. She hadn't killed them, she vehemently maintained. The poor things had starved

to death and she'd merely tried to dispose of the bodies: first, on a makeshift paper pyre in her living room, and then, when that tactic failed, by cutting off their legs with a kitchen knife to make them fit inside a big Oaxacan-style plant pot, given to her by her mother months earlier.

José, journalist: 'The court was packed with officials, reporters and some sickos who came along just to hear the murderer's confession... She appeared behind bars; she looked like shit, the poor thing, hunched over and a real mess in a skirt, trainers and a white T-shirt that was way too big for her. Her blonde hair was all greasy and her chin was down by her chest... She never looked up during her entire testimony, not once could I get a look at her eyes. It was like she was scared of people; she was holding onto the rusty bars and her hands were trembling... Her lawyer, Pedro García Reyes – Pistol Pete, we called him, because he was a thug like the Disney character – was perched on one of the female court clerks' desks, smoking furiously; he spent the whole hearing yelling at the prosecutor, Nohemí Quirasco, interrupting her cross-examination... When the time came, Evangelina said she hadn't killed her children, she claimed they'd starved to death because she couldn't afford to feed them, and she hadn't mentioned anything to her family because they weren't on speaking terms... Then the prosecutor asked her why she'd buried the bodies in a plant pot and, damn, Evangelina just started shaking and said, "I was scared"... "Scared of what, or whom?" Quirasco asked, but that supercilious, overbearing prick Pedro objected to the question, on the grounds that it was irrelevant... To tell the truth, by this point I thought there was something fishy going on, like they were hiding something... That's why when the judge ordered she take all those psychiatric tests right away, I predicted they were going to try to pass her off as insane, and look what happened...'

From her very first appearance before the judge, the reporters were openly sceptical of Tejera Bosada's statements, and went public with the medical examiner Gil Trujillo's conclusions: namely, that Jaime's and Juan Miguel's deaths had been caused by a series of closed head injuries and the two boys died several days apart, Juan Miguel first. In his 7 April article, Edgar Urrutia Hernández, a crime reporter for *El Dictamen*, claimed that Evangelina was a 'compulsive liar', with a reputation for 'regularly making up stories and living in fantasy land', while Héctor Ramón López, a correspondent for the *Diario de Xalapa*, described the event as 'the most abhorrent case in the city's history', and repeatedly reminded his readers of Evangelina's profile as the 'ex-carnival party queen who turned into a schizophrenic woman charged with the horrific murder of her two children'. Although the defendant claimed, in her first appearance before the judge, that she had previously undergone treatment with the psychiatrist Camerino Vázquez – the director of a small mental health clinic in the city – the public, whose moral outrage was supposedly reflected in the tabloid reports, would dismiss this as a lie, a 'legal trick' to help Evangelina 'bypass criminal proceedings and evade punishment for her spine-chilling crime'. Reporter Urrutia Hernández would also point out, in a story dated 8 April, that the prosecution employed 'a soft touch' when cross-examining the defendant. The behaviour of Judge Carlos Rodríguez Moreno was equally 'paternalistic' when he voiced his suspicion that Tejera Bosada suffered from mental disorders, establishing a precedent that the accused and her defence would exploit to 'bend the case in her favour', given the total absence of 'proper legal rigor'.

A group of lawyers from Veracruz, headed up by the ex-mayor Jorge Reyes Peralta, was convinced that the public would not settle for anything less than the harshest of punishments. The team went to the Public Prosecutor's Office the Monday after Tejera Bosada's detention and requested legal authorization to assist the prosecution and thus lawfully intervene in the trial against Tejera Bosada and prevent the defendant from evading justice by 'feigning madness'. In a statement to the press, Reyes Peralta – today the senior partner in one of the most powerful law firms in the city of Veracruz – stated that he was convinced beyond all doubt that Tejera Bosada had acted 'with unprecedented cruelty in murdering her two young boys, for the sole purpose of causing nonmaterial damage to the father of those children – children she frequently and ruthlessly abused'//

Neither the rumours that Evangelina Tejera had suffered from long-term mental illnesses – with symptoms including depression and uncontrollable violent outbursts – nor her thorny romantic relationship with Mario But who was Evangelina Tejera Bosada? Who was this woman who, just six years earlier, had been crowned by the people of Veracruz as their glitzy queen, and was now being accused by the very same community of an unspeakable crime? How could this fair-haired beauty, only recently awarded the highest honour to which an unmarried Veracruz girl could aspire, have become the impassive waif now splashed all over the tabloid crime pages?

Tomasa, shopkeeper: 'Oh yes, she was pretty, she could have almost passed for a gringa with her green eyes and pale skin... She'd started young with the boys; there was even one who knocked her about, but then she was a bit nuts herself, you know?... She'd been a stoner since she was fifteen, but she really showed her true colours after she was crowned Carnival Queen, what with all the parties and hanging around in trendy clubs with the rich set... They say she only ever went with "juniors", daddy's boys who would snort a load of coke and then drive around in their fancy cars doing all sorts of craziness; some of them had even killed people, but nothing ever happened to

1 Above all cocaine, which, starting in the eighties, was being sold at increasingly accessible prices in Veracruz. It is no coincidence that when *El Dictamen* broke the story of Tejera Bosada's crime on 7 April 1989, the second biggest story in the crime section that day reported the seizure of eighty-four kilos of cocaine in a truck arriving from Guatemala. One federal worker claimed, 'Never before in Veracruz's history has so much cocaine been seized as the quantities intercepted in the region of late.'

them because the police were there to cover for them... I remember Picho Malpica, he killed Polo Hoyos's daughter just because she refused to go out with him; and there was Miguel Kayser, who dealt coke at all the parties... Some say he sold to Evangelina and the boys' father, De la Rosa, and that they'd use the National Lottery building apartment to sell coke and marijuana to other addicts and have orgies... And that it was during one of those orgies that she just flipped and killed the two kiddies...'

Born in 1965 to a stay-at-home mother – whose name didn't appear in any of the documents I consulted – and Jaime Tejera Suárez, an estate agent, Tejera Bosada was brought up in a home where, rumour has it, verbal and physical violence were the norm, at least until her parents' marriage fell apart. Under pressure from both her mother and the worsening economic crisis of the early eighties, a teenage Evangelina was forced to abandon her studies before completing secondary school, taking a job as a secretary for an import-export company in town. Tejera Bosada and her father grew closer after her mother remarried: he encouraged Evangelina to run for Carnival Queen 1983, and according to the social pages published in February of that same year, he was the sole parent to attend, 'with great emotion, the coronation of his beautiful daughter'.

In Veracruz, the selection of the Carnival Queen has more to do with the candidate's socioeconomic status than with her physical attributes. The queen is chosen from a group of candidates according to her purchasing power – the crown is awarded to the woman with the highest number of votes, which are bought from the festival's organizing committee with hard cash. In the context of Mexico's 1982 debt crisis, Tejera Bosada's ascent to the Carnival throne necessarily suggests that her family (or at least her father) had the support of an entire network of contacts, who were prepared to pay for votes as well as her royal trousseau. The social pages from the time entirely overlook such crude details, choosing instead to exalt Evangelina's grace and charm ('Her Majesty is eighteen years of age, enjoys playing tennis and piano and is a great fan of contemporary music,' read one profile in *El Dictamen*), as well as the way this 'fair beauty' cheerfully represented 'the joyfulness of the Veracruz people', in 'a reign of fantasy and illusion'. The media played down both the violence that invariably took place on the city's streets during Carnival (the assaults, the sexual harassment and abuse, the public intoxication and often lethal injuries) and the grim sight of a Veracruz completely overrun by mobs of people, which local writer Ignacio García, in an article from the time, compared to 'Melquíades's raggedy band of gypsies arriving in a muddy Macondo'. Instead, society reporters admired 'the beautiful decorations and colourful lights', 'the collective joy' of the Veracruz people, characterized by 'their amazing good humour and ability to see the bright side, their refusal to get worked up about the crisis or the fall in oil prices, or anything that might cast a shadow over their lives'. In the words of reporter Alfonso Valencia Ríos, a representative of the city's pro-government media, Carnival let people 'forget about the economic crisis eroding the country, forget about the lack of foreign exchange and the brutal inflation pulverizing salaries', offering instead 'the pleasure of a marvellous parade of floats, troupes and costumes', which were all examples of 'the grace, beauty, inventiveness, wit and creativity' of the Veracruz people.

It's here, at the height of this delirious party, this bacchanal of revellers doing its best to camouflage reality with confetti, tinsel and booze, that the Veracruz myth locates the beginning of Evangelina Tejera Bosada's fall from grace. Moving from dance to dance, cavorting with the rich and powerful, Evangelina celebrates, drinks, smokes and, most likely, takes drugs to keep up with the real party, the one that only gets going *after* the official parade is over, when her formal gown, which looks like something out of nineteenth-century Austria-Hungary, is switched out for fashionable tops and jeans. In her escapades at Veracruz's late-night hot spots, during the endless processions along the city's coastline and at the social events where she's obliged to dance with anyone who asks, Evangelina dazzles and enchants all who encounter her: the crowds drunk on beer and the succulent samba girls imported from Brazil and Cuba, as well as the 'rich daddy's boys' – progeny of the city's customs brokers, hoteliers, restaurateurs and senior government officials – who had snubbed her before her coronation; the older men who gush about the colour of her eyes, as well as the newspaper poets who dedicate verses to her and publish them in the Sunday papers:

> Evangelina the Second,
> with Artemis's style:
> Venus bitterly envies
> The candour of your smile.
>
> Across Heroic Veracruz
> its people cheer and scream
> Moved by the austere smile
> of fair Evangelina their queen.

Looking at photos of this triumphant Evangelina – draped in costume necklaces and bracelets, silver-and-white frills, her hair in an elegant updo, feathers in her headdress and sequins on her dress – and then at images of the broken, crestfallen woman published six years later – no longer in gossip rags but in the crime pages of the newspapers, alongside crooks and degenerates – it's impossible not to search for signs of a disturbed mind developing behind that radiant face. Is that a twinkle of evil cunning, perhaps, in the queen's eye? Isn't there a hint of weariness, or even strain, in the stiff smile plastered on her face? Isn't there something cruel about her indifference as she avoids looking into the photographer's lens? As she sat on her papier-mâché throne, her lowly subjects calling out to her over the hubbub of hecklings, obscenities and laughter, could Evangelina have already begun, even as early as then, to sense what the future had in store for her? Perhaps Mario de la Rosa was already on her mind during the festivities, while the 'incredible voice' of Dulce, 'the biggest singer of the moment', performed live, singing the ballad that would become – along with hits

by songwriter Rafael Pérez Botija, sung by José José and Rocío Dúrcal – *the* anthem for co-dependency and emotional worthlessness, the defining zeitgeist of the eighties:

> I'll be your lover or whatever it takes
> I'll be what you ask me to be
> I mean it, my love,
> Do what you want with me
> Queen, slave or woman
> Just let me come back to you.

On 10 April 1989, after her initial detention period was over, Evangelina Tejera Bosada was brought before Judge Rodríguez Moreno, who signed an order of imprisonment against the accused. 'Upon discovering her true legal position, the woman who murdered her children wept for the first time,' wrote a correspondent for the *Diario de Xalapa*, relishing Tejera Bosada's suffering and her visible distress and agitation, which his 'well-informed sources' put down to drug-withdrawal symptoms. J. P. de León, a journalist for *El Dictamen*, described the judge's ruling as 'thorough and well founded', since the imprisonment order would make it hard for the defence attorney to invoke Article 418 from the then Code of Penal Procedure, which // in language yet to be acquainted with political correctness // allowed a criminal trial to be terminated 'at the first indication that the accused is either insane, an idiot, an imbecile, or suffers from any other incapacity, infirmity, or mental abnormality'.

Public opinion was divided: some speculated that Evangelina killed her sons because they got her in her way; others thought that she committed the crime in a jealous rage after discovering that De la Rosa had a new lover, and that she was now trying to pass for a madwoman to avoid a prison sentence. There were also those who believed that Tejera Bosada had genuinely suffered a psychotic episode, brought on by her drug abuse, and a select few refused to believe that the young mother could have been capable of committing such a heinous act and suggested that the boys had been murdered by someone else seeking revenge. Finally, there were whispers that the old Carnival Queen was part of a 'narco-satanic' sect, a rumour that perhaps sprang from the exceedingly gory manner in which the boys, Jaime and Juan Miguel, were killed and mutilated, or perhaps simply because it was something of a hot topic at the time: in May 1983, every newspaper in the country reported on the arrest of the gang known as The Narco-satanists and the death of Adolfo de Jesús Constanzo, alias the Godfather, the leader of this criminal group-cum-satanic sect, which not only trafficked drugs between Mexico and the United States but was also accused of the abduction, rape and ritualistic murder of at least fifteen people.

Just a few days after Tejera Bosada was imprisoned in a high-security cell in the Ignacio Allende prison, Judge Rodríguez Moreno ordered the formation of a medical advisory board that would examine the defendant and determine whether she had a psychiatric disorder that exempted her from criminal punishment. Having assessed her, the medical experts concluded that Evangelina Tejera showed signs of 'antisocial personality disorder, kleptomania and an acute psychotic episode', and while they ruled out frontal lobe epilepsy, they did recommend to the judge that the defendant undergo specialized psychiatric and neurological examinations. Doctors David Reyes and Alberto Miranda were selected to carry out the first of these examinations, which began on 8 May at Veracruz General Hospital and concluded almost two months later with discouraging results for the defence: Evangelina's behavioural disorders did not stem from any kind of endocrine or brain pathology. It's not clear what happened immediately after these two assessments; the press was no longer covering Evangelina Tejera's story. One has to access the criminal trial records to find out what happened next: on 7 March 1990, almost a year after the crime was discovered, Judge Rodríguez Moreno acknowledged the defendant's mental incapacity and arranged for her to be admitted to the Orizaba Psychiatric Hospital 'for as long as it takes for her to recover her mental health'. The treatment seemed to work, as three years later, on 16 November 1993, Dr Gregorio Pérez concluded that Tejera Bosada had fully recovered.

But the defendant did not get to enjoy her newfound freedom. She was detained at the doors of the hospital by a group of judicial police officers with a new arrest warrant, who drove her back to the Ignacio Allende prison in Veracruz to resume the trial for the voluntary manslaughter of her two children. The public – and, in particular, the team of lawyers led by Reyes Peralta – could not and would not let the crime go. Three years after the case reopened, Judge Samuel Baizabal Maldonado sentenced Evangelina to twenty-eight years of imprisonment and a fine of thirty-five pesos.

Using several different public defenders, Tejera Bosada did everything in her power to appeal this new ruling and avoid imprisonment, citing the violation of her legal rights – she had been put on trial twice for the same crime. Nonetheless, none of her attempts was successful. As far as Mexico's Supreme Court was concerned, the resumption of the trial immediately after Tejera Bosada's discharge from the psychiatric hospital was perfectly legal, since the evidence presented by the prosecution adequately demonstrated that her mental illness didn't begin until *after* she committed the crime. According to the Supreme Court judges who reviewed the dispute, the twenty-eight-year prison sentence imposed by Baizabal Maldonado in 1996 was fair and unappealable, since it had been proven beyond all reasonable doubt that when Evangelina Tejera beat her children against the floor and walls of her living room, dismembered their bodies, buried them in a plant pot, placed said plant pot on the balcony in plain view of half of Veracruz, and then walked around naked for several days in front of the windows of her National Lottery building apartment, she acted at all times 'in full possession of her mental faculties'.

Daniel, pimp: 'I don't think she killed those boys... She wasn't a violent person... She was more of a party animal, a druggie – deep into her weed and coke, sure, but she wasn't crazy... At first I did believe she'd killed them, because there were times it seemed like those boys just got in the way of her highs, but then I thought, No, she wouldn't

be capable of that, and definitely not chopping them into pieces... I was always over at her place; we'd all hang out there... Mario, Kayser, Guillo, Tiburcio, Picho, Cara de León; the boys would roll up and there'd be all sorts... Man, that was some world-class blow, like from back in the day, not the nasty shit they sell now. It came in sort of flakes, crystals almost... Cost about a grand a gram but, boy, did it fire you up... There were always people in that apartment getting fucked up, drinking, dancing... And the kids, well, in their room, of course... Yeah, I saw them once or twice; they were little blond things, like her... personally I think Evangelina lost it afterwards, after what she went through... I think it was the narcos who killed those kids, in revenge, because she and that dickhead De la Rosa snorted all the coke and spent all the money... I think that's why she never confessed to doing it but at the same time never ratted on whoever did. Because she'd rather live with the stigma than have the narcos come after her and kill her. And that's why she hooked up with that guy from Los Zetas cartel on the inside, to protect herself from her enemies...'

Evangelina's case didn't appear in the press again until 2007, a decade after her definitive sentence, when her name became linked to a character both feared and revered by the crime tabloid writers of the early aughts: Óscar Sentíes Alfonsín, better known as Güero Valli. Originally from Cosamaloapan and detained several times for robbery, possession of illegal arms and drug-related crimes, Sentíes Alfonsín was considered a dangerous prisoner and was suspected of being one of the principal drug smugglers into Veracruz's jails. He was also suspected, according to articles written by Lourdes López, César Augusto Vázquez Chagoya, and Miguel Ángel López Velasco, of being Tejera Bosada's new romantic partner. Apparently, they had met in jail in Pacho Viejo, Perote, where they were both transferred: Evangelina because of the constant clashes she provoked among the other female prisoners inside the Ignacio Allende, and Sentíes Alfonsín for organizing several rebellions at the Villa Aldama federal prison. For his repeated misbehaviour, the authorities punished Güero Valli with the 'carousel' – continuous transfer between penitentiaries – a strategy that supposedly prevented the purchase of 'privileges'. When they transferred Güero Valli from Perote to Amatlán, Evangelina Tejera went with him, and in May 2008 they were both part of the 'chain' of prisoners sent to a brand-new prison in Coatzacoalcos. According to the journalist Miguel Ángel López Velasco (who wrote under the pseudonym Milo Vela until he was assassinated in June 2011, allegedly by members of organized crime), on the day of the prison's opening, Sentíes Alfonsín spoke to the then-director of Social Rehabilitation for the state, Zeferino Tejeda Uscanga, to 'push' the case for the early release of 'his woman', who had served exactly half of her sentence. By then it was an open secret that the prisons in Veracruz were controlled, from the inside, by Los Zetas, which had recently broken away from the Gulf Cartel: they provided the inmates with drugs and granted privileges, like the ones Evangelina Tejera required in order to go on living in the Coatzacoalcos prison with Sentíes Alfonsín, despite the fact that she was now eligible for early release. And she enjoyed that privilege until October 2008, when Sentíes Alfonsín was stabbed to death by a fellow inmate in a punishment cell, where he'd been put for allegedly trying to organize another revolt.

As Michel Foucault points out in the book *I, Pierre Rivière, Having Slaughtered My Mother, My Sister, and My Brother: A Case of Parricide in the 19th Century*, every crime must serve some purpose to society because a completely gratuitous crime, one without any motive at all, is unimaginable. The community must instead come up with unique and singular causes for the crime, thereby ruling out any reflection on the structural conditions surrounding it and passing over connections between that crime and other cases from the same period. In Tejera Bosada's case, these would include the economic crisis, violence against women, the breakdown of the family, and Mexico's failed social security and child protection systems.

I've always been troubled by the contiguity that exists between the social pages and sensationalist 'bleeding leads', and I don't only mean their physical proximity in Veracruz's newspapers (they are often published on facing pages, mirroring each other), but because both genres tend to present the subject matters of their 'literature' as exceptional, one-off, unrepeatable events. First, the rise of a young woman to the status of Carnival Queen, a living symbol of the joyfulness, vitality and fecundity of Veracruz's people; then her subsequent disgrace as the murderer of her own children, a mythical villain, a fairy-tale witch whose name is invoked by mothers all over Veracruz telling boys and girls to eat their vegetables, or else 'Evangelina will come and punish you.' Contradictory yet complementary archetypes. Masks that dehumanize women, acting like blank canvases on which to project the desires, fears and anxieties of a

Three decades after the double homicide that shook the people of Veracruz, the whereabouts of fair Evangelina are still unknown. Some accounts claim she returned to the city and now lives as a recluse in a miserable downtown tenement, obese, ailing and out of her mind. Other rumours have it that a family member employed her: in an optician's office, some say, or in a medical laboratory, or a veterinary clinic. Some claim to have seen her in the luxury hotel resorts on the Riviera Maya, svelte, dripping in jewels, on the arm of the big bosses from Los Zetas, to whom it's said she must have turned to for protection after Güero Valli's assassination.

And while the legend of her crime lives on in whispers, to this day it is still possible to walk to the top of Independencia, stand on the corner of Calle Melchor Ocampo, look up at the National Lottery building, and search its west facade for the balcony of apartment 501. Perhaps the constant flow of pedestrians along that street will prevent the inquisitive person from standing there very long, but with a bit of luck, they'll glimpse the yellow light that on some nights, for a matter of hours, goes on in that apartment. And perhaps a terrible thought will flash through their mind: that just like her children, the old Carnival Queen, the convicted murderer Evangelina Tejera Bosada, has herself become a ghost.

ONE NIGHT I got into a car with two very friendly guys with brown hair who took me to a corner store in Barrio Yofre, by the railway tracks. It was three in the morning. On the way, the one driving said he liked my perfume. They offered me cocaine from a baggy that someone had torn open with their teeth. I was in the back with one of them, doing my thing. Not the cramped quarters in a small car nor the passing traffic can stop me from doing my thing. I liked them both, especially the one next to me. The driver parked the car in the middle of that bleak part of town and we went into the store in silence. It was run by the driver's mother and she was a light sleeper. In the storage room at the back, a kind of purgatory zone between the store and the house, between bags of candy and crates of beer, I got to work. Suddenly the owner's son told us to be quiet. We could hear his mother calling for him, asking who was there and what they were doing. "Nothing, Ma, we came to pick up some beer. Go back to sleep, it's late," he called. But his mother went on and on and eventually the guy told us we had to go somewhere else.

The other one, the one I liked, suggested his apartment a few blocks away. We got dressed, broke camp after taking a few bottles of beer from the refrigerator, and went on to the next place. This time, the guy I liked drove. He was like a gift from heaven. There wasn't an ounce of skin on him that I wasn't tempted by. He smelled good, dressed well, had green eyes and a chiseled body. His companion was different: an edgy, scrawny cocaine addict who smelled bad, dressed worse, and was clumsy with me.

We arrived. It was almost four in the morning. The street was deserted. We went inside and they asked me to lie on the bed. That's when your survival instincts kick in: my feelers went out like a snake tasting the air. It's when the john starts acting naturally, when they feel they have a right to demand things. All prostitutes get goose bumps about then. Prostitutes should only do what they're comfortable with: the john's wishes are immaterial. A whore with any sense of self-worth never gives in. This is when the john needs to bend to the wishes of the whore, believing that it's what they wanted all along. And they need to pay for it. There was a large jar on the nightstand, the kind they use to keep olives in, but this was full of coins. The walls were decorated with martial-arts-style weaponry. Different-sized sticks, as phallic as you like. The boys gave me cocaine and ecstasy. The apartment was horrible. The place was deathly ugly, it reminded me of my parents' decor.

I was naked in bed. They got undressed too and started to play with me. All three bodies were naked but one was appreciably more vulnerable than the other two. Letting yourself go in these situations makes you dizzy. I began to feel light-headed and nauseated. I asked them to give me some time to catch my breath and they moved off. Then I just tamely fell asleep. I'd never slept like that in my life. Everything simply froze and went black. When I opened my eyes again it was dawn. Harsh light streamed in through the curtains. They were dressed now, sitting at the computer, watching porn and drinking beer. At first I couldn't remember where I was or with whom. The monitor was playing images of naked girls, all of whom were asleep while being penetrated by the sticks hanging on the walls, with bottles, with their own arms. Suddenly I saw myself on screen with a bottle of beer coming out of my ass and one of their faces resting on my butt cheek. A lovely image for the Christmas card. I pretended to still be asleep. I couldn't hear what they were saying. I felt very weak. Then I passed out again. I dreamed of a riverbank, a lovely town on the prettiest river in the world. It was sunset, I was walking down the bank into the water, willow trees blocked out the sky. I wanted to go back to the town, back to my room. Bats the size of humans hung from the branches. They were asleep. On the ground, spread out like leftovers from a feast, were the massive bones of cows, with flies and pools of blood. I woke up feeling disgusted.

I managed to lift myself up on my arms, touched myself, and immediately knew that they'd done what they liked with me. The sheets were stained with semen, shit, and blood. They still had their backs to me, looking at the computer. I cleared my throat. "You fell asleep," they said. Really. My eyelids felt heavy. It was cold. The sun wasn't streaming in anymore but the light hurt just the same. I went back to sleep.

When I woke up I saw the one I liked lying next to me, he'd fallen asleep too. The other one, the unpleasant one, was still taking cocaine at the computer. He was jerking off naked. When he saw that I was awake he came over and wanted another round but couldn't keep his erection. Instead of giving up, he kept on trying. His friend woke up and started to watch. The impotent one got angry with me, telling me I couldn't keep his dick hard. I didn't have the strength, but far from giving up, I acted. I acted better than Jessica Lange, Anna Magnani, Annie Girardot, and Marlene Dietrich put together, I summoned all my acting goddesses and they came to my aid. I pretended to be attracted to my aggressor. The other one was a little more sober. He'd woken up in a good mood, the piece of shit. I pulled him over and told him I wanted to finish the party with him alone. I wasn't going to charge but said we should go to my house so we could get some peace and quiet. At home I had every pleasure he could think of. I was a girl armed to the

teeth with party supplies.

He brought a note of sanity to the proceedings. He called a taxi for his friend and took me home in his car. On the way I started to shake. I thought that I was going to die then and there. "Don't you die in my car, honey," he said. I could barely answer.

When we got to the boardinghouse, I collapsed against the door trying to get my key in the lock. He got scared. He dragged me inside and disappeared. I slept the whole day through. When I woke up I checked the time, day, and month. Then I took a bath as quick as I could and rushed out to college. A professor was waiting for me.

Since it's the fifteenth – payday – the lines stretch almost all the way back to the produce section. You look for a less crowded register, but a lot of people are doing the same thing, and it's no use: you'll have to wait.

There are so many people in the supermarket that they've run out of magazines to flip through, and the only thing left to look at is the ceiling, your nails, the other women's trolleys, and you think to yourself: *For a country that's going bankrupt, it's nice people can still buy three kinds of American cereal*. And finally, half-dead from boredom and wanting to murder the crazy woman buying mountains of toilet paper, you look into your own trolley to make sure you didn't forget anything. It's a ridiculous exercise because if something's missing, too bad: if you leave, you lose your spot. You've never been able to do what other people do, hold up the line because you forgot something, whether it be milk or fabric softener.

The first thing you see are the sardines: red tins stamped with greyish-blue fish that look very happy, but surely aren't. *Did I get enough?* you ask yourself. He likes to eat sardines with yucca and onion at least once a week. *Why does he love sardines so much?* you wonder as you give in, glance around, and slowly open a bag of potato chips. That act of rebellion, eating things in the supermarket before paying for them, is one of the few you allow yourself.

It's the only one you allow yourself.

Why does he love those fucking sardines? you think. *They're like aluminium foil, with those little bones that scratch the roof of your mouth. They taste like salty mud.*

The children can't stand them either, but he loves them, he demands them, and so you always get four tins a month, even though he is the only one who's going to eat them, even though you'll have to cook something different for yourself and the kids.

Beside the sardine tins, the artichokes peek out like hand grenades. *Abominations. Why does he like them? They're expensive, hard to eat, and almost tasteless*. You have to steam them for him and serve them with a sauce made of cheese, Tabasco, and mustard, and once he finishes nibbling the tips of the leaves – *like a big fag*, you think – you have to pick up his plate, get rid of the hairy parts – *like a gringa's pussy, disgusting* – and come back to the table with the hearts cut up and covered in sauce.

He eats the hearts with his hands.

You stare at the beers. He's capable of smacking the kids if he gets home from work and doesn't find his can of beer and frozen mug waiting for him. Everything just how he likes it. As much as you try, you can't cure the children of their obsession with that mug: they're fascinated by the water inside it and the little colourful fish floating around. One day he found Junior drinking out of it and shaking it to make the fish move. He made his head swivel with a slap, and his orange juice flew all over the room. That wasn't a toy. It was *his* beer mug, and the next time he saw Junior with it, he'd burn his fingers with matches.

'I'm going to burn your hand if you ever touch my mug again,' he said, picking up a piece of paper and holding it over the flame of a lighter. 'Like this.'

You have to wash the mug and keep it in the freezer until he walks in the door at 5:45 p.m. Not a moment sooner. Not a moment later. You have to take it out, open the beer, and serve it, tilting the cup and the can so that there isn't too much foam. Nor too little. He's capable of calling you a moron, a retard, a bitch if you don't do it right.

'You idiot, you ruined my beer. I know you did it on purpose, you're always trying to fuck me over.'

There is also *his* yoghurt. The vanilla yoghurt with strawberry jam at the bottom. He takes them and puts them in the freezer of *his* refrigerator, as he calls it. Every night he eats one while he watches television lying in *his* recliner. He counts them, the yoghurts, he counts them, so when the kids, who love desserts, eat one, you have to say it was you and endure his tirade without looking up until he exhausts himself, because, oh, if you look up—

'Are you challenging me, huh? Are you fucking challenging me, you piece of shit?'

Sometimes he makes you go to the shop, no matter what time it is. Even if it's raining. It's your punishment: you've taken what isn't yours. Worse: you've taken what is *his*.

You keep looking at the trolley. You don't have the cereal the kids asked for, and you feel bad. If you got that cereal, you wouldn't have enough money for the steak, and he likes his fillets without any gristle, without any fat. He likes expensive fillets even though he won't let go of one red cent for the rest of the month after buying them. So you grabbed three boxes of off-brand cereal instead, one for each child, and the worst brand of pads, the scratchy ones, the ones that come apart right away and cover your panties in little balls of fluff.

But you have the flank steak and the peanuts to make him his guata, the Coffee-Mate he takes to the office, the Kleenex for his car, his *Stadium* magazine, the fried beans for watching the game, the passion fruit for his juice. Passion fruit: with its snot-like texture, you don't understand how anyone could like it.

Once again, you've bought the discount shampoo, the one that's like washing with dish soap. The one that makes your hair look nice is the other one, the one you never buy.

As you are lost in thought, the line moves forward: the woman in front of you takes the last things out of her trolley. This woman is buying the shampoo for colour-treated hair that every month you say you're going to buy for yourself. She doesn't have any sardines. She doesn't have artichokes.

She looks at you, smiles, and sets the little divider across

the conveyor belt, that little metal barrier that separates her purchases from yours. Her shampoo from yours. Her choices from yours.

Someone returns an empty trolley. You put it beside your full one. You transfer to this other trolley the sardines, the beers, the guata ingredients, the beans, the fucking artichokes, the shitty yoghurts, the goddamn Coffee-Mate, the snotty passion fruit, and the copy of *Stadium*, with all its asshole Barcelona and Emelec players, each one worse than the last.

'Are you getting that?' the cashier asks, pointing to the other trolley.

You look at her.

'Ma'am, are you going to get that?' the cashier repeats, jutting her chin at the trolley with the shining tins of sardines.

You shake your head.

She calls over a boy to return everything to the shelves. You look at him out of the corner of your eye. He looks at you. You nod for him to take it all back. And, smiling, you say some words to yourself that no one else can hear.

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